Voice of the Downtrodden

INDERPURI JJ COLONY IS ONE of those rough-and-tumble shanties where the State goes absconding, in the very rain shadow of Lutyens' stately capital grid. Kumari Mayawati Das was a 21-year-old teacher there, dreaming of the IAS, when Kanshi Ram came visiting her family home. The year was 1977. He was still on his way to becoming India's biggest Dalit icon after Ambedkar—famously cycling to thousands of dusty meetings to create a politically empowered *bahujan*. His protégé, though, came to embody not only his vision but also a vastly more supercharged ideal of mobility. As India's first female Dalit chief minister in 1995, trumping both gender and caste bias, she went on to create a deified version of herself—elevating herself to marble statuary, always sculpted toting a handbag. The very thing that was a subject of mirth for the sneering caste elites was a symbol of hope for the benighted masses she spoke to. In her prime, Mayawati lorded it over the plains of Uttar Pradesh like no one else, unlocking it as a development destination for the first time, making it briefly a magnet for the magnates, laying down the Taj Expressway and the rule of law over its lawless realms, bringing a shiver to the spine of dominant caste thugs in the outback and the police brass in their towelled *kursis*.

In line with her guru's credo, she allied with every possible side to amass and magnify power for her Dalit-centred BSP: fraternising with Mulayam Singh Yadav till a bitter falling-out, pitchforking herself to office with the help of the BJP, crafting a Dalit-Muslim coalition of the oppressed, reverting to a Dalit-Brahmin entente, consorting with the Left for a failed prime ministerial candidacy, and making up with Mulayam's son Akhilesh Yadav for a *mahagathbandhan*, a grand idea that earned a hasty burial. Her fortunes have been on the wane, through successive assembly poll debacles in 2012, 2017 and 2022, the BSP winning only one seat and 12.7 per cent votes the last time, in a state where the Dalits account for 20 per cent. The seven-time parliamentarian and four-time CM has tried every trick in the book to stay relevant, including staying enigmatically silent on her next move. Her presence in 15 states (and a national vote that once topped 6 per cent) keeps the INDIA bloc very interested—and the BJP very eagle-eyed. It's that old unpredictable mobility. ■

–Sunil Menon with Prashant Srivastava



Mayawati, 67
Former Chief Minister, Uttar Pradesh

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↘ THE HANDBAG It is so much a part of her symbolism of the aspirational Dalit that her proud supporters say, on a lighter note, of her statues: "They are only an accessory to the handbag"

↘ ROUGH HEWS To Lucknow's genteel culture, epitomised by the phrase '*Pehle aap*', she brought the more egalitarian roughness of western UP lingo... replete with '*tu, tum, tera*'. The old elite turn up their noses, but that's also why her supporters enjoy it

ACCOMPLISHMENT

The first woman Dalit chief minister of UP, she once led the BSP to the No. 3 party status in national vote share—a potential that makes her moves a prize riddle for 2024